

Norway imposes near ban on AI in elementary school

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OSLO, June 19 (Reuters) - Norway is imposing a near ban on the use of generative AI tools by elementary school pupils while also restricting their use in the education of older children to prevent a negative impact on learning, the country's prime minister said on Friday.

Facing a broad decline in education test scores, the government in 2024 banned smartphones from schools and has given teachers back more powers to enforce discipline in the classroom.

Using AI increases the risk that young children skip important steps in their education, Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Støre told a press conference on Friday.

"The most important thing in school is that our children learn to read, write and do mathematics," Støre said, adding that the new standards will be imposed from the new school year beginning in late August.

Pupils from first through seventh grade, aged 6 to 13, should as a general rule not be using AI, while those in lower secondary school, aged 14 to 16, can cautiously adopt

tools under teachers' supervision, the government said.

In upper secondary education, from ages 17 to 19, students should learn to use AI appropriately so that they are prepared for further education and work, it added.

Norway began adopting computers in classrooms in the 1990s and tablets after the introduction of the iPad from 2010 onwards, reducing the reliance on books and handwriting.

But in a related statement on Friday the government also said it will propose legislation to fund the use of more books in classrooms, reversing the trend towards computer tablets.

The Norwegian government in April also announced plans to ban children from using social media until they turn 16, following a trend pioneered by Australia and some other nations to reduce young people's use of electronic devices.

(Reporting by Terje Solsvik; Editing by Kirsten Donovan)

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